



SUBIR HALDER / www.indiatodayimages.com

In a state with 26 per cent Muslims, Banerjee plays the minorities card well and blatantly uses her ministry for expanding her constituency.

over the implementation of the Unlawful Activities Prevention (UAP) Act. Revolutionary Socialist Party (RSP) state secretariat member Manoj Bhattacharya said, "For the first time, we will hold an open convention against the state using the UAP Act against extremists. We will bring to public notice the arrest of Maoist frontman Chhatradhar Mahato under the same Act when the state Government had repeatedly said that it had yet not implemented it."

Says Saifuddin Chowdhury, one time mercurial CPI(M) MP who has now formed his own Peoples' Democratic Front after he was "disillusioned" with the activities of the party, "I

don't know where the proverbial communist sympathies of West Bengal are headed for. I left the party in disgust and am absolutely happy the way I am trying to carry forward the movement. Inside the CPI(M), it had become claustrophobic." It is this claustrophobia which silences men like Land Reforms Minister Abdur Rejjak Mollah, once touted to be Bhattacharya's deputy chief minister, but has fallen foul of the party after the Vedic Village fiasco last month. "We are going wrong and the results are showing. Unless we set our focus right, we will go downhill and the party will not allow that. Let the Opposition do whatever it wants, but we know that the people are with us. However, we have noticed that at the grassroots level, there is total confusion and the masses are being fed wrong ideas. Our comrades have become too complacent," said the state party boss Bimal Bose.

Perhaps the worst period of the CPI(M) has been the last two years: the Nano-Singur-Nandigram events, followed by panchayat elections, topped by the Lok Sabha, closely followed by the sudden emergence of the Maoist spectre, and finally capped by the Vedic Village scandal, all combining to make the party the worst villain in the political scenario.

A major chink in the Left's armour has been the near total alienation of the intellectuals of Kolkata from the movement. After the Nandigram police firing on March 14, 2007, in which 14 villagers were killed, filmmakers Aparna Sen and Rituparno Ghosh and poets like Sankho Ghosh took to the streets led by an ageing Magsaysay Award winner Mahasweta Devi, who is now openly feted by Banerjee at public functions. Sen told Bhattacharya at Writers' Building,

SHIFTING SUPPORT OF THE LEFT FRONT IN RURAL AND URBAN AREAS

Occupational Groups	Vote Share in 2009(%)		Gain/Loss of the Left since '04 (Percentage Points)
	LEFT	CONGRESS and TRINAMOL	
RURAL			
Agricultural workers	46	41	-2
Skilled and Semi-skilled workers	30	59	-16
Marginal farmers+share croppers	44	53	+1
Farmers	31	65	-26
Salaried Class	62	35	+23
URBAN			
Professional and salaried	44	44	-3
Business Class	39	51	-15
Skilled and Semi-skilled workers	57	37	+3

Source: CSDS NES 2004 and 2009 Post-Poll Survey